

Geography as the Architect of the Soul:
The Sherpa of Nepal vs the Wakhi of Afghanistan

A Comparative Case Study

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Introduction:

The rugged terrain of the Himalayas and Hindu Kush do more than define the borders of Nepal and Afghanistan; they serve as the ultimate architects of the cultures nestled within them. In the northeastern region of South Asia lies Nepal's Solu-Khumbu district, in which the Sherpa have spent centuries at the base of Mt. Everest (Chomolungma – “The Mother of the World”), helping to transform this high-altitude landscape into a sacred network of hidden valleys and Buddhist protector deities (Ortner, 1999; Furer-Haimendorf, 1964). While thousands of miles to the west, within the high altitudes of the Afghan Wakhan (Wakhan Corridor), the Wakhi people maintain an equally profound relationship with the Hindu Kush, practicing a unique blend of Ismaili Islam that mixes ancient mountain shrines with a resilient agropastoral lifestyle (Soelberg, 2016; Mock, 2011). Both mountain-dwelling groups face unique challenges; with the Sherpa of Nepal having to navigate the pressures of global mountaineering tourism and the Wakhi of Afghanistan having to endure decades of geopolitical isolation (Ortner, 1999; Aliprandini, 2024). However, both groups share a similar worldview, one in which geography becomes a living, spiritual participant rather than simply an obstacle to overcome. By comparing these two mountain-dwelling groups, this paper attempts to explore the ways extreme vertical environments shape identity, arguing that these cultures offer a powerful contrast to western mentalities. For, through their eyes, human existence is defined not by the mastery of nature, but through a sacred and rhythmic partnership with it.

Geographic and Climatic Profiles:

As *The World Today: Concepts and Regions in Geography* explains, both Nepal and Afghanistan reside within the fringes of the South Asian region, acting as buffers between East and Central Asia (2020). Both regions are characterized by extreme altitudinal zonation, with a

drastic decrease in oxygen and temperature as one travel from the valley floors to the alpine pastures. In Nepal, the Sherpa have made their home within the Himalayas, where massive glaciers and sheer verticality dominate the landscape, with its highest peak reaching a staggering 8,848 meters high (Bailey, 2025). In contrast, the Wakhi call home where the peaks of the Hindu Kush meet the Pamir mountains, with its highest peak reaching 7,485 meters in height (Mock, 2011; Aliprandini, 2024). While Nepal experiences monsoons that support high-altitude forests, Wakhan is a high-altitude desert, described by Jens Soelberg as the place where survival is heavily dependent on agropastoralism (2016). Regardless of these climatic disparities, both the Sherpa and the Wakhi share a vertical existence, where every aspect of life is dictated by the steepness of the terrain.

Historical Background and Migration Dynamics:

Christoph Von Furer-Haimendorf explains within *The Sherpas of Nepal; Buddhist Highlanders* that the Sherpa are recent migrants from Tibet that came in almost untraceable waves in an effort to escape from various forms of political and religious upheavals. Furer-Haimendorf further explains that this migration allowed them to preserve a highland culture that shows clear distinctions from the heavily Hindu influenced cultures in the lower valleys of Nepal (1964). In contrast, Shahrani explains within *The Kirghiz and Wakhi of Afghanistan: Adaptation to Closed Frontiers and War* that the Wakhi are one of the oldest inhabitants within their region, though they were greatly affected by the “Great Game” between Russia and Britain during the 19th century. During this time, the Wakhan Corridor was intentionally used as a buffer between these two empires, one that worked to prevent them from crossing. Because of this, the Wakhi were left in a state of isolation, allowing them to maintain ancient traditions that have begun to vanish in the more accessible areas of Afghanistan (2002).

Spiritual Geographies and Sacred Landscapes:

The geography of Nepal and Afghanistan is not merely a physical reality to the Sherpa and Wakhi but a spiritual roadmap. As Lindsay Skog explains in *Beyul Khumbu: Sherpa Constructions of a Sacred Landscape*, the Sherpa view the Himalayan region as a *beyul*, “a sacred place and hidden valley (p 3, para 1),” one in which the physical peaks of the mountains are the literal homes of their protector deities. She explains about the formation of *Lungdar*, prayer flags – a set of five flags representing the elements, which are placed within mountain passes, sacred sites and even the tops of homes. These flags are believed to release prayers with every wave in the wind. Though they also believe heavily in land spirits, in which the natural features, springs, rocks, trees, mountains, etc. are themselves animated by living spirits, referred to as *lu*, *sadak*, and *tsen* (2010). Which somewhat mirrors what John Mock describes of the Wakhi’s shrine traditions, in his article *Shrine Traditions of Wakhan Afghanistan*, explains that there are three types of shrines, the *ostan*, *qadamgah*, and *mazar*. The *ostan* are described as trees decorated with colored strips of cloth or as a collection of stones with a unique color, shape, or markings, often located near a natural feature. For the Wakhi, these shrines are often considered thresholds between the human realm and the divine (2011). Regardless, for both groups, the environment is not a curse or trial to be overcome, rather, the difficulty of the terrain itself acts to protect the sanctity of their spiritual worldviews.

Contemporary Socio-Economic Challenges:

When it comes to the challenges facing the Sherpa of Nepal and the Wakhi of Afghanistan, it becomes evident that these challenges are unique in some respects. For the Sherpa of Nepal, their challenge arises out of the struggle to maintain a balance between the spiritual reverence of their environment and the economic reality of global mountaineering.

Within *Life and Death on Mt. Everest*, Sherry Ortner explores how this joint reality has forced the Sherpa to navigate a world in which their sacred places and spaces have become a mere playground in the pursuit of Western enjoyment. Which has created a form of psychological and spiritual friction: their religion dictates that the mountain peaks are the revered home of their deities, not to be disturbed; their livelihood depends on guiding people to those very peaks (1999). While Lionel Obadia highlights in their article *The Conflicting Relationships of Sherpas to Nature: Indigenous or Western Ecology*, that this conflicting reality has led to the evolution of indigenous ecology, wherein the Sherpa have had to adapt their traditional worldviews so that they can incorporate modern environmental protection. The Sherpa have used this inherent tension as a means to evolve, increasingly taking up leadership roles within the mountaineering trade to ensure that both their people and their sacred places are respected (2008).

For the Wakhi of Afghanistan, their challenges derive from the inherent geopolitical turmoil within Afghanistan. As M. Shahrani explains within *The Kirghiz and Wakhi of Afghanistan*, the Wakhan Corridor has been historically isolated from the mainstream centralized Afghan government. While this isolation helped them to retain many of their traditional practices, it has greatly affected their access to basic resources. Once nomadic, the political tensions within this region caused a drastic alteration in their living patterns, causing them to settle in the mountains, near oases, and disrupting trade (2002). Soelberg et al. highlights this tension through the lens of ethnobotany in their article *Comparative ethnobotany of the Wakhi agropastoralist and the Kyrgyz nomads of Afghanistan*, mentioning that the Wakhi's extensive knowledge of plants is not simply a cultural choice, but a necessary one in response to the absence of modern healthcare. The Ismaili worldview of the Wakhi, with a focus on communal self-reliance, has allowed them to meet these hardships head on and to maintain a sense of

stability (2016). Even with these political tensions, the Wakhi have been able to strengthen their local communal bonds and maintain their unique identity.

Author Positionality and Cross-Cultural Reflections:

Coming from my personally eclectic religious background, I find both the Sherpa of Nepal and the Wakhi of Afghanistan to be beautiful cultures with unique religious practices. While I do not practice Buddhism, Islam, or Hinduism, I find the inherent ideas to be profound and inspiring. My family and I do, however, have a mixed religious household. As both I and, more extensively, my husband has traditional religious roots, our home is a mixture of mainstream Christianity and traditional beliefs. Which seems almost comical or contradictory but makes sense for our family. Sort of similar to the ways in which the Sherpa have been influenced by Buddhism and Hinduism. My husband's paternal great grandfather was a product of the Indian Boarding School program here in the United States, and when he was released, he bought land in what was historically his tribe's domain here in Arkansas and worked to keep their traditional beliefs alive in his descendants. So, my husband grew up with a vastly different worldview than most mainstream Americans, and admittedly myself, with a particular reverence for the natural world. While I had always been drawn spiritually to the natural world, I was raised in a very Christian household throughout my childhood, though we went through several different denominations. As I got older, I began to broaden my horizons and attempted to regain the heritage my family had lost during the Great Depression, reconnecting to my own traditional roots through the Cherokee.

Within Young Hoon Oh's paper, *Sherpa Intercultural Experiences in Himalayan Mountaineering: A Pragmatic Phenomenological Perspective*, it mentions that the Sherpa preform a puja, a specific act of worship, before every single expedition (2016, pp 64-66). This

act of worship isn't the same as a Christian prayer. While similar, in that it is a method for connecting with the divine for protection and blessing, it has more of a focus on acknowledgement of the significance of the undertaking, it is communal and animistic, focusing on the mountain spirit. More similar to the traditional hunting rites my husband practices, with a sense of gratitude and respect for the natural world around him, like the ways in which we pay respects to the animal that was harvested, thanking it for the life it sacrificed to provide life for us and recognizing it as its own spiritual entity. Christianity often views the natural world as something to control, something that they have dominion over, while more traditional beliefs view the natural world as significant as the human one. The ways in which the Wakhi find spiritual meaning within stones, springs and trees, also mirrors many Native American traditional values, in that they spiritually based in nature, focusing on animism with a deep respect for natural forces, animals, and environments. So, I cannot say I was genuinely surprised by the things that I learned about the Sherpa of Nepal and the Wakhi of Afghanistan while preparing for this paper, but I did find them to be interesting and engaging explorations.

Conclusion:

Ultimately, the Sherpa of Nepal and The Wakhi of Afghanistan prove that geography is far more than a mere physical constraint, but rather a spiritual foundation. While those in the modern or western cultures may view the high-altitude peaks of the Himalayas and Hindu Kush as frontiers to be explored, controlled or conquered, these communities offer a crucial alternative – a worldview rooted in humility, resilience, and through a sacred partnership with the land. My exploration of their lives has not only deepened my understanding of the diversity inherent within the Sout Asian region, but it has also allowed me to reflect on my own heritage and the ways we all endeavor to seek a connection with the divine through a physical world. By viewing

the world through the lenses of the Sherpa and the Wakhi, we can see the ways in which extreme environments elevate human diversity, rather than limit it, highlighting just how vibrant the human spirit can be when it is rooted deeply within the natural world it inhabits.

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